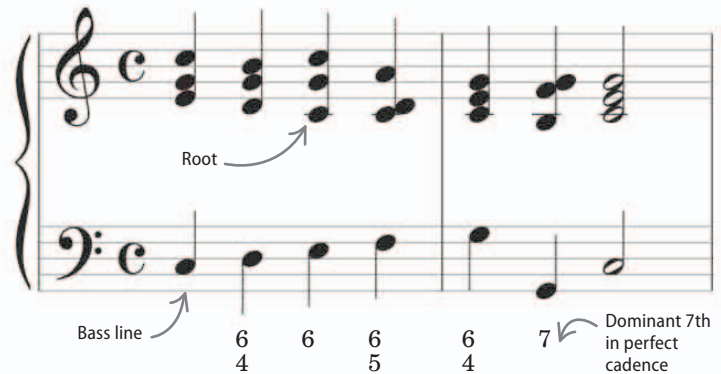


Basso continuo

Baroque musical performances were held together by the “continuo.” This was an accompaniment played by a keyboard instrument and bass instrument, such as a cello. Instead of a written-out part, the notation was simply a bass line with chord indications below. The bass line was played by the cello, while the keyboard player interpreted the chord indications.

▷ Playing continuo

The keyboard player chooses chords according to the numbers below the bass line. These showed the intervals needed to produce the correct chords.



Obbligato

A contrasting (counter) melody played against the main tune is known as an obbligato. It is a familiar counterpoint in Baroque sacred music, usually played by a solo instrument in a duet with a singer, over an accompanying string ensemble. The violin, oboe, and flute were the favored instruments for playing obbligato.



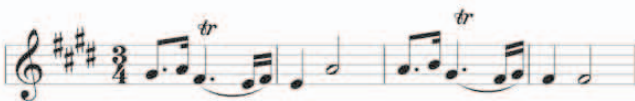
△ “*Quia respexit*” from *Bach’s Magnificat*
In this aria, the melancholy sound of the oboe d’amore—slightly larger version of a standard oboe—is pitted against a solo soprano.

Dancing rhythms

Courtly dances provided the rhythmic basis for many Baroque instrumental works. Sarabandes, gavottes, minuets, bourrées, and gigue (jigs) were grouped together and presented as a varied “Suite,” or used as a single movement in another work.

▽ Bach’s *French Suites*

The slow sarabande is in triple time, with emphasis on the second beat. So is the graceful minuet, while the sprightly gavotte starts, unusually, on the third of four beats.



Sarabande from Suite no. 6



Menuet from Suite no. 3



Gavotte from Suite no. 5

REAL WORLD

Johann Sebastian Bach

The German composer, J. S. Bach (1685–1750) was a celebrated master of counterpoint. He composed organ and keyboard works, instrumental music, and religious choral works, including motets, cantatas, Passions, and a Mass in B minor.

